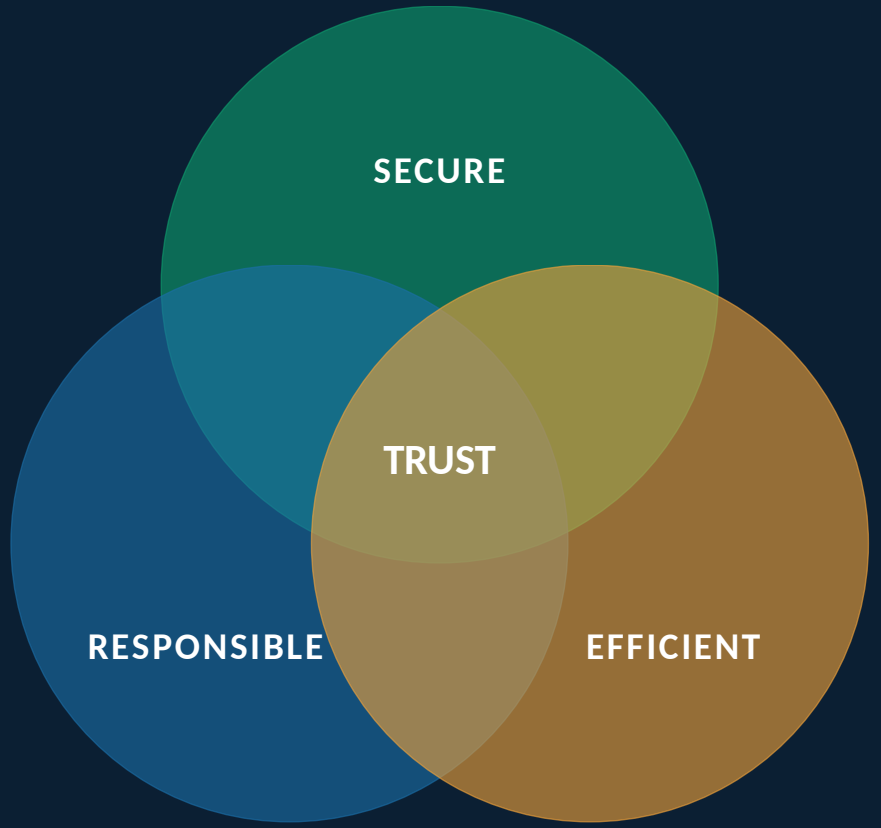
LIMERICK IT SUMMIT 2027 · THE AUTOMATION TOOLKIT

# Student Hackathon Proposal

A student strand for the summit on Thursday 25 February 2027




**Mohit Behl · Volunteer Coordinator**

Prepared for the summit organisers · November 2026

# The proposal at a glance

Students build automation tools for real SME problems and show the best on summit day.

**3**

### Rounds

Online idea round, online build sprint, then an on-site finale

**11**

### Challenge tracks

The summit's ten automation areas, plus an open track

**24 h**

### Grand Finale

Saturday 20 – Sunday 21 February 2027, the weekend before the summit

**20–25**

### Finalist teams

About 80 to 100 students from institutions across Ireland

**25 Feb**

### Summit showcase

Winners demo and pitch; attendees vote an SME Choice award

**1**

### Shared baseline

The Trust Triad: secure, responsible, efficient

# How the hackathon serves the summit

Each of the summit's four goals gets something concrete from the student strand.

### Community Education

Students learn automation, security and responsible AI through mentoring and workshops, and meet the Mid West business community.

### SME Focused

An SME Challenge Bank of real problems, tracks that mirror the summit's automation areas, and an SME Choice award.

### Practical and Accessible

Open to every eligible student; practical, open-source tools SMEs can try; accessibility built into every project.

### Charity Focused

An optional community challenge from the summit's charity partner, if it agrees, and a wellbeing-first finale.

### Fits the summit date

Finale on 20–21 February; winners present at the summit on Thursday 25 February.

### Grows the community

Brings students and institutions into the summit's network as future attendees, staff and founders.

# Why automation needs trust now

The summit says automation should be introduced responsibly. Recent developments show why.

### AI is regulated

EU AI Act transparency duties apply from August 2026; high-risk rules from December 2027.

### Attacks hit suppliers

Ransomware on a check-in system supplier disrupted Dublin Airport in September 2025.

### Clouds fail too

A major AWS outage in October 2025 was traced to a race condition in DNS automation.

### Computing costs energy

Data centres used 22% of Ireland's metered electricity in 2024 (CSO).

### Accessibility is law

The European Accessibility Act has applied in Ireland since 28 June 2025.

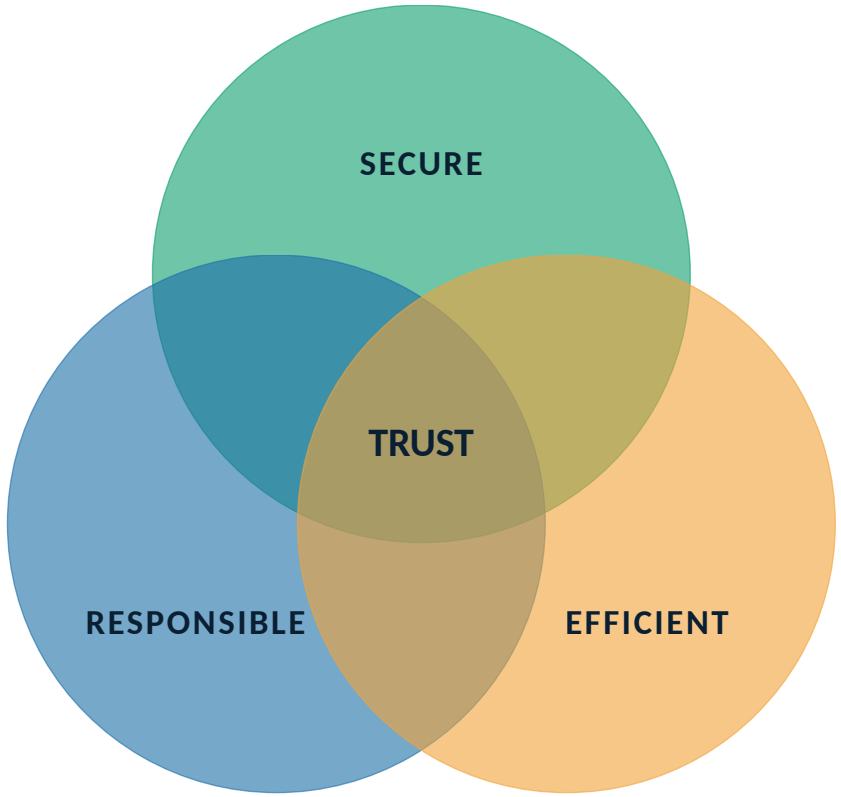
### Cyber law tightens

EU Cyber Resilience Act reporting began September 2026; Ireland has yet to transpose NIS2.

Sources: report Appendix C, checked 4 November 2026. Regulatory dates should be re-checked before participant materials are published.

# The Trust Triad: one baseline for all

Not a separate track: every project in every track shows these three qualities.




## Secure

No secrets in repositories, authentication for personal data, and the top three threats mitigated

## Responsible

Lawful, licensed data; AI use disclosed; a person approves important decisions; WCAG 2.2 basics

## Efficient

Right-sized models and infrastructure; fails safely if one part fails; optional energy estimate

**Evidence:** a one-page Trust Card per team · 10% of the finale score · three special awards

# Challenge tracks 1–6

Tracks 1 to 10 follow the automation areas on the summit website.

TRACK 1

### Business processes and administration

Turn paper or email processes (quotes, timesheets) into tracked workflows

TRACK 2

### AI and intelligent assistants

Assistants that answer from a firm’s own documents and cite their sources

TRACK 3

### Sales and marketing

GDPR-aware lead follow-up; draft posts for a person to review

TRACK 4

### Customer service and communications

Inbox triage with suggested replies; booking and reminder flows

TRACK 5

### Finance and reporting

Invoice and receipt capture with a human check; cash-flow summaries

TRACK 6

### Cybersecurity and compliance

Cyber-hygiene checks for micro-businesses; phishing awareness tools

# Challenge tracks 7–11

Plus an SME Challenge Bank of real problems from local businesses.

TRACK 7

### Websites, platforms and integrations

Accessibility checks for small online shops; reliable system connectors

TRACK 8

### Data management and decision-making

Dashboards from existing spreadsheets; data-quality checks

TRACK 9

### Workforce productivity

Rota and shift optimisation; meeting notes turned into actions

TRACK 10

### Startup and business operations

Stock reorder automation; a back office for new start-ups

TRACK 11

### Open track

Any automation idea for SMEs or the community; the Trust Triad applies

### SME Challenge Bank

Local businesses submit real problems through the summit's community; teams get a short call with the business in Round 2.

# Three rounds, rising commitment

Round 2 tests feasibility before anyone travels, which cuts no-shows at the finale.

## 1 Idea submission

**Online · closes 22 Jan**

- Registration opens 7 December
- 6-slide idea deck (template supplied)
- Two screening judges per deck

**→ Up to 40 teams shortlisted**

## 2 Mentored build sprint

**Online · 2 – 9 Feb**

- 20-minute mentor session
- SME call for SME challenges
- 3-minute video and draft Trust Card

**→ 20–25 finalists + 5 waitlist**

## 3 Grand Finale

**On site · 20–21 Feb**

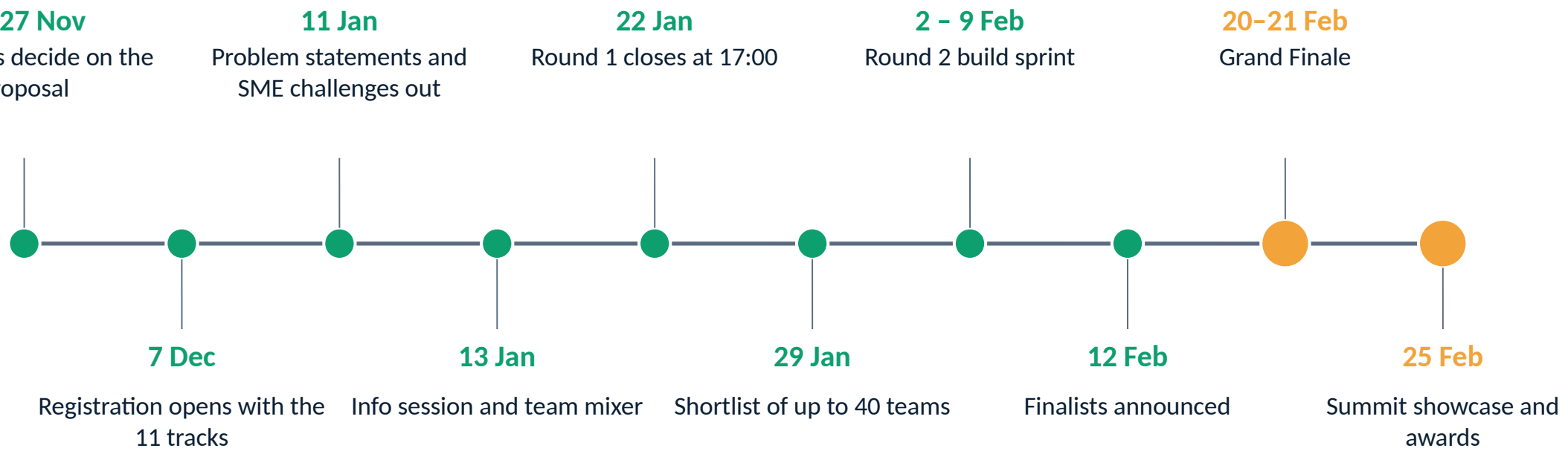
- 24-hour build from a declared baseline
- 3 mentor rounds, 2 workshops, a mini-CTF
- Panel judging, then a final for the top 6

**→ Winners present on 25 Feb**

*Plan B: a two-day format without an overnight stay if overnight use of the finale venue is not possible.*

# Timeline to summit day

Planned backwards from the summit on Thursday 25 February 2027.




*December is kept light for exams and holidays, and no deadline falls on the St Brigid's Day bank holiday (Monday 1 February).*

# 24-hour finale run-of-show

One hard deadline that matches the end of hacking, with mentoring and rest built in.

| Time | Saturday 20 February |
|---|---|
| **07:30** | Check-in and lanyards |
| **09:00** | Opening, rules and Trust Triad |
| **10:00** | Orientation; repositories tagged |
| **11:00** | **Hacking starts (H+0)** |
| **14:00** | Workshop: securing LLM apps |
| **15:00** | Mentor round 1 · scope locked |
| **18:00** | Workshop: accessible UIs (WCAG 2.2) |
| **21:00** | Mentor round 2 · core flow working |
| **00:00** | Mini-CTF (optional, 90 minutes) |

| Time | Sunday 21 February |
|---|---|
| **01:30** | Overnight build; helpdesk and first aid |
| **08:00** | Mentor round 3 · demo rehearsal |
| **11:00** | **Code freeze and hard deadline (H+24)** |
| **11:00** | Checks and judge calibration |
| **12:45** | Panel judging: 3 panels in parallel |
| **14:45** | Expo and People's Choice vote |
| **15:30** | Final: top 6 teams |
| **17:00** | Results and closing |
| **18:00** | Close and venue handover |

*Meals: 13:00 lunch · 19:00 dinner · 23:30 snacks · 07:00 breakfast · 12:00 lunch. Winners present at the summit on Thursday 25 February.*

# Summit day: Thursday 25 February

The summit’s programme sets the times. The hackathon needs tables, a short stage slot and a vote.



1

### Before doors open

About 8 to 10 showcase tables for winning and special-award teams, with posters and QR codes for demos and Trust Cards.



2

### During breaks

Teams demo to SME owners and other attendees, who vote for the SME Choice award by QR code.



3

### Main-stage slot

Three-minute pitches from the overall winners, the awards, and thanks to partners and SMEs.



4

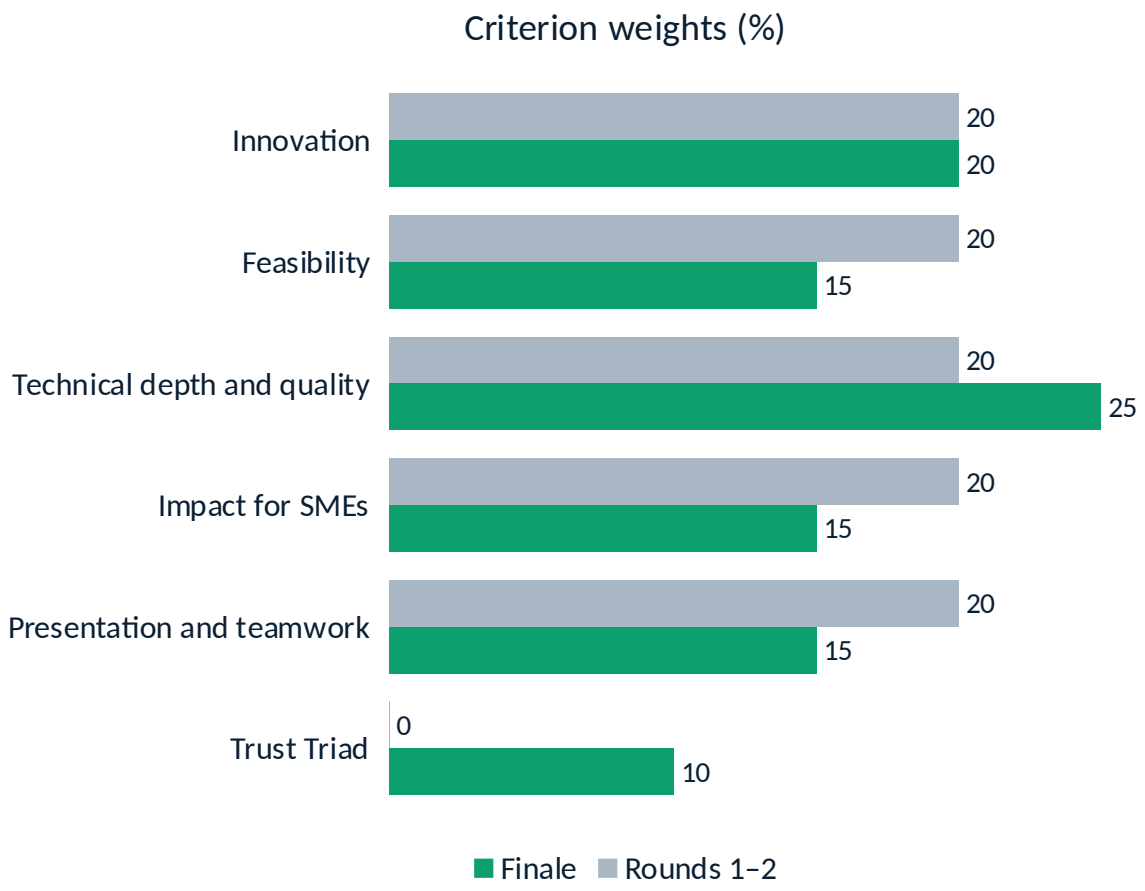
### After the summit

Introductions between teams and interested SMEs for pilots, internships or further development.

Finalists get letters for their institutions to support weekday attendance. If a winning team cannot attend, its recorded pitch is played.

# Judging rewards quality and trust

The online rounds use five equal criteria; the finale moves weight to working quality and trust.




**Panels:** 3 parallel panels of 3 judges; the top 2 from each go to a final panel of 5 that includes an SME owner

**Calibration:** judges score one sample pitch together before scoring starts

**Conflicts:** declared in advance; conflicted judges do not score that team

**Tie-breaks:** technical depth, then impact, then a vote of the final panel

**Appeals:** lodged within 30 minutes and decided within 60

# Eight things that make it distinctive

Each one is achievable with free or open-source tools and a volunteer team.

### Trust Card

One page per team: data, AI use, top risks, accessibility, efficiency, limits.

### Declared-AI policy

AI tools allowed if declared; every member can explain the code.

### SME Challenge Bank

Real problems from local businesses, tagged to the 11 tracks.

### Summit showcase

Winners demo to SMEs at the summit, which votes an SME Choice award.

### Mentored build sprint

An online Round 2 tests feasibility early and cuts no-shows.

### Mini-CTF and workshops

Overnight capture-the-flag; LLM-security and WCAG sessions.

### Secure operations

MFA for organisers, capped per-team API keys, phishing alerts.

### Build-on pathway

Six-week mentored sprint; links to SMEs and campus enterprise support.

# Rules and compliance for Ireland

Terms that suit students and SMEs, with GDPR, safeguarding and venue duties covered from day one.

## For participants

- Aged 18+ and enrolled at a higher-education institution in Ireland
- Teams of 2–4; teams can mix institutions
- Teams keep their IP; organisers get showcase rights
- AI allowed if declared; existing code must be declared
- Open, synthetic or consented data; SME data only with permission
- One hard deadline and one grace policy for everyone

## For organisers

- GDPR privacy notice, minimal data, deletion after 12 months
- Photo consent and a “no photos” lanyard
- Code of conduct, named contacts, women volunteers overnight
- Allergen information and dietary options
- Venue liability cover and approval for overnight use
- Legal review of the IP terms and declared-AI policy

# Ten workstreams, one volunteer coordinator

The organisers keep the decisions; the Volunteer Coordinator runs the hackathon day to day.




Finale staffing estimate: about 16 volunteers per day shift and 7 overnight (about 35 recruited), plus about 6 for the summit-day showcase. At least two women volunteers on the overnight shift.

# Resources and partner support

Mostly in kind, through the summit’s existing community. Commercial arrangements stay with the organisers.

| Resource | What is needed |
|---|---|
| **Finale venue** | Limerick campus or partner premises |
| **Food and drink** | ~155 people at peak, 6 meal points |
| **Internet and power** | Venue IT; backup line |
| **Mentors and judges** | About 15 across the weekend |
| **SME challenges** | At least 10 from local businesses |
| **Prizes** | In kind, from partners |
| **Materials** | Lanyards, signage, digital certificates |
| **Volunteers** | About 35 for the finale, 6 on summit day |

**Mentor or judge**
A few hours across Round 2 or the finale

**Set a challenge**
Submit a real problem to the SME Challenge Bank

**Run a workshop**
30 minutes on a practical automation topic

**Support in kind**
Venue, food, connectivity or prizes

# Risks we plan for

Event basics, plus the cloud, AI and cyber issues teams will meet in industry.

| Risk | Fallback |
|---|---|
| **Internet or power fails** | Backup line, hotspots and backup power; extend the deadline by the outage length |
| **Submission platform goes down** | Email or shared-drive backup, checked by timestamp |
| **Medical or safety incident** | First aid, emergency list, incident log |
| **Cloud or AI API outage** | Recorded demo plus a code walk-through, with no penalty |
| **Phishing aimed at participants** | Official channels published; warnings from the operations room |
| **API keys leaked** | Per-team keys with usage caps; revoke and reissue |
| **Personal-data incident** | Data controller’s breach procedure; GDPR 72-hour rule where required |
| **Severe weather or transport disruption** | Watch Met Éireann warnings; switch to an online finale |
| **Short January window for Round 1** | Registration opens in December; extend Round 1 by up to three days if needed |
| **Dispute over AI use or existing code** | Repository tag, commit history, appeals panel |
| **Winners cannot attend the weekday summit** | Letters for their institutions; recorded pitch played at the showcase |

# How we will measure success

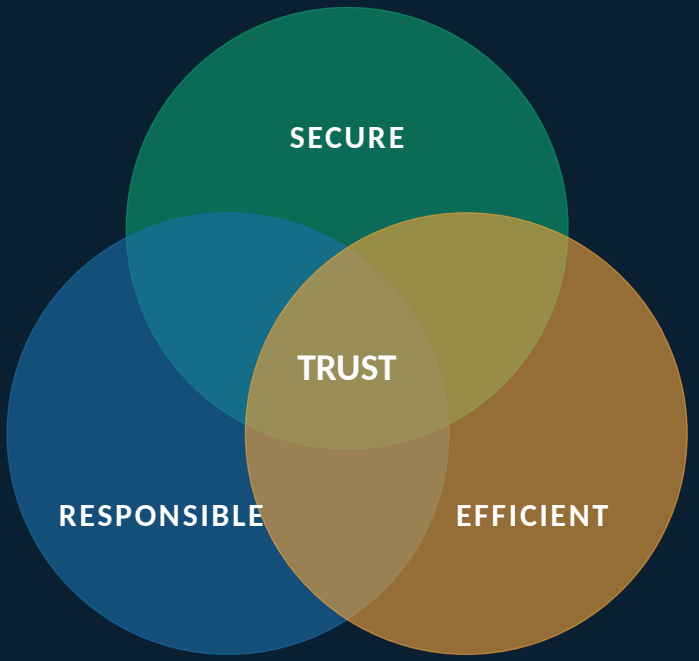
Proposed targets for a first edition, reported to the organisers after the summit.

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **≥ 90%**<br>Finalist attendance against confirmations | **≥ 80%**<br>Finalist teams demo a working prototype | **≥ 8**<br>Institutions represented in Round 1 | **≥ 30%**<br>Women and non-binary participants |
| **≥ 10**<br>SME challenges in the Challenge Bank | **≥ 4 / 5**<br>Average participant satisfaction | **0**<br>Serious safety or data incidents | **≥ 3**<br>Teams continuing with an SME within 3 months |

*Measured from check-in, judging, survey and Challenge Bank records. The report also tracks Trust Card completion, 30-day project activity and partner satisfaction.*

# What we need from the organisers

1. Endorse the hackathon as a student strand of the summit
2. Agree showcase tables and a short stage slot on 25 February
3. Help reach SMEs for the SME Challenge Bank
4. Introduce partners for mentors, judges and in-kind support
5. Agree a finale venue and overnight use (or Plan B)
6. Approve the IP terms and declared-AI policy, after legal review
7. Approve the 11 tracks and name an owner for each




**Decisions requested by 27 November 2026**

Mohit Behl, Volunteer Coordinator